Tips for Inclusive Facilitation for White Teachers

Kitsy Schoen, MSW and Crystal A. Johnson, Ph.D.

- Specifically welcome everyone (see Canticle welcome)
- Specify the cultural norms (e.g., Agreements for Multicultural Interactions) and use them as a way of building a safe-enough community.
- Use inclusive language, e.g.,
    - Use appropriate gender pronouns
    - Avoid coded racist language: Good/bad schools, good/bad neighborhoods, thug, urban, inner city, black-on-black crime, radical Islam, illegal alien/immigrant, uppity, bossy, sassy, working like a slave/slaving away, "all chiefs and no indians", Unamerican, Uncanadian
    - Avoid language of the gender binary
        - Saying "men and women" when you mean "everyone"
        - Saying "he or she" rather than "they"
    - Avoid ableist language
        - Avoid words such as "blind, lame, crazy" when meaning "ignorant, inept or confusing"
        - Assume a diversity of physical abilities when giving meditation instructions
- Be attentive to who is participating. If a few people, or a category of people (e.g., white men) are dominating the discussion, invite other voices into the discussion. Don't call on the same few people all the time.
- Always teach as if there is deep diversity in the room. This communicates that mindfulness really is a practice for everyone, and avoids reinforcing the dominant narrative/white-only assumption.
    - If you use quotes, quote from a diversity of authors/speakers
    - Careful about using "we" when what you mean is "white people" or "middle class people" or "Americans"
    - Use teaching examples and illustrations that reflect the broader culture, not just white, middle class, heterosexual.

- Acknowledge the dramatic impact of systems of oppression and offer teachings relevant to people suffering in this way. Don't assume that personal/individual situations are the dominant concern for everyone. Don't assume that you understand the experiences of oppressed groups, even if you yourself have subjugated identities (which most of us do, of course).
- Create a diverse teaching team and develop the teaching approach/course plan together. Prior to, and during the course, explicitly discuss the dynamics of privilege and oppression as they are present in the team. These practices will allow you to create a safe enough space for practice for a diverse group of students.
- Establish robust feedback mechanisms
    - In the beginning of a class, let the group know that you are speaking from a specific social positioning and that you invite their feedback if you do something harmful. And let them know how you want to receive the feedback (in the moment, email later, etc.)
    - Offer regular opportunities for feedback: feedback forms, dedicated class time to feedback discussion, anonymous surveys, etc.
- Understand that there will be diverse reactions to your teaching; neither the positive nor the negative feedback is the "truth." "Positive" feedback doesn't mean you're doing a good job, and "negative" feedback doesn't mean you're doing a bad job. What you're aiming for is a group where people feel free to explore and express their own experience, without encountering your ego resistance.
- Create practices/processes from the start to invite participation from those who have not yet spoken. Pay attention to who is participating/dominating.
- Address microaggressions when they arise; go back to them if there is more to do. Attend to the experience of those who have spoken, and the rest of the group as well.
- Respond non defensively when called out; see this as an opportunity to learn as well as to model the value of inclusivity.
    - Thank the person for raising the issue
    - Instead of trying to "calm things down," think about trying to "name what's true"
    - Create space/time in the group to acknowledge and respond to impact
    - If you are triggered/overwhelmed and not sure how to respond, you can pause the group and ask everyone to reflect on what just happened. Invite those who had a similar response to share, if they can. Make a commitment to think it over/get consultation and come back to it later.
    - Consider using the concept of comfort, discomfort and alarm zones to support group members to neither shut down nor demand/expect to stay in their comfort zone.
    - If you are able to respond skillfully in the moment, offer apology and appropriate repair. Do not explain why the person misunderstood you or is wrong.

- Consider classroom set ups that are more egalitarian, e.g., circles where participants can all see each other and are not strictly focused on the teacher.
- When receiving challenging feedback, respond from your position of role privilege as a teacher. As a teacher you have a responsibility to attend to the impact that arises from this position of privilege.
- As a teacher, you have a position of privilege, however we may be triggered from our own subjugated identities, for example, a woman teacher might be triggered by the feedback of a male student.
- Make a practice of being transparent about the teaching decisions you are making; it helps people not take these decisions personally. E.g.,
    - “This discussion is wonderful, and I’m having to make a decision to move on.”